

FIELD PERSPECTIVE • NOT A SALES PITCH

Right-Sizing Microsoft Cowork

How to scope agentic Copilot to the users who actually benefit, and stop sizing it by headcount.

A practical framework for deciding who gets Cowork vs. Copilot Premium



The cost question is built on the wrong math

THE WRONG MATH

5,000

seats × a scary per-user number

- Assumes everyone uses it the same way.
- Treats Cowork like a license to spray across the org.
- Produces an unbounded, anxiety-driven number.

THE RIGHT MATH

~5-15%

of users whose work is genuinely project-shaped

- Size by work shape, not by headcount.
- Give the rest Copilot Premium, which already covers them.
- Now the spend is bounded and defensible.



One question separates Premium from Cowork

Does this person repeatedly do work that is **multi-step, spans multiple sources, and ends in a structured deliverable** they currently assemble by hand?

NO → COPILOT PREMIUM

In-the-moment assistance:

- Summarize this thread
- Draft this reply
- Catch me up before the meeting
- Clean up this doc

Premium already covers them. Cowork would mostly idle.

YES → COWORK

Project-shaped work:

- Kicks off something that pulls from five places
- Produces a report, deck, model, or package
- Runs longer and does its own stitching
- Replaces hours of manual assembly

Pays off because it replaces expensive human hours.



Three tiers, and the top one stays small

BUILDERS

Project-shaped, multi-source, deliverable-producing work.

The smallest tier

ASSISTED

In-the-flow help: drafting, summarizing, catching up.

The broad middle

CONSUMERS

Frontline and task workers with light, occasional needs.

Everyone else

Right-size from the top down. The Builders tier should feel uncomfortably small at first. That is correct.



These are work patterns, not job titles

Analysts & researchers

Clinical, financial, market. Synthesize many sources into one report on a cycle.

FP&A & finance

Recurring reporting, reconciliation, and variance narratives every month.

Program & ops managers

Coordinate across systems; produce maintained status and tracking docs.

Consultants & pre-sales

Build proposals, briefs, and decks from scattered inputs.

Legal & compliance

Multi-document review and summarization at real volume.

Chiefs of staff / exec support

Assemble briefing and prep packages from many feeds.

In a health system, the dense pockets are research & analytics, revenue cycle / finance, compliance & contracting, and the PMO. Not the clinicians and frontline staff.



Who does NOT need Cowork

Frontline & task workers

Their day isn't project-shaped. No deliverable to assemble.

In-the-moment Copilot users

"Help me with this thing right now" is exactly what Premium does.

Light email / meeting / doc users

Occasional needs don't justify an agentic seat.

People with a domain agent already

Engineers with coding agents, etc. Already covered elsewhere.

Telling a customer who shouldn't get it is the most credible thing you can do. It's the opposite of a sales motion.

How an organization actually picks (not a vibe)

1



Tier the population first

Consumers, Assisted, Builders. The Builders tier should feel small.

2



Use signals, not nominations

Who burns Premium heavily, runs long prompts, owns recurring deliverables.

3



Run a cohort, not a rollout

Start with 50-150 of the clearest Builders and measure real outcomes.

4



Set a payback threshold up front

Decide what "worth it" means: hours saved or deliverables automated.

5



Expand by work shape

Add the next pocket of Builders, not "the rest of the department."

THE RESULT

Turns "5,000 seats, fingers crossed" into "we earned our way up from 100, and every added seat passed a bar."

HOW TO LAND IT

“Don't give this to 5,000 people. Find the few hundred it's actually for, and why the rest of your users are already covered by what you have.”

Size by work shape

Not headcount, not title.

Premium covers most

Cowork is for the Builders.

Earn the seats

Cohort, measure, expand.